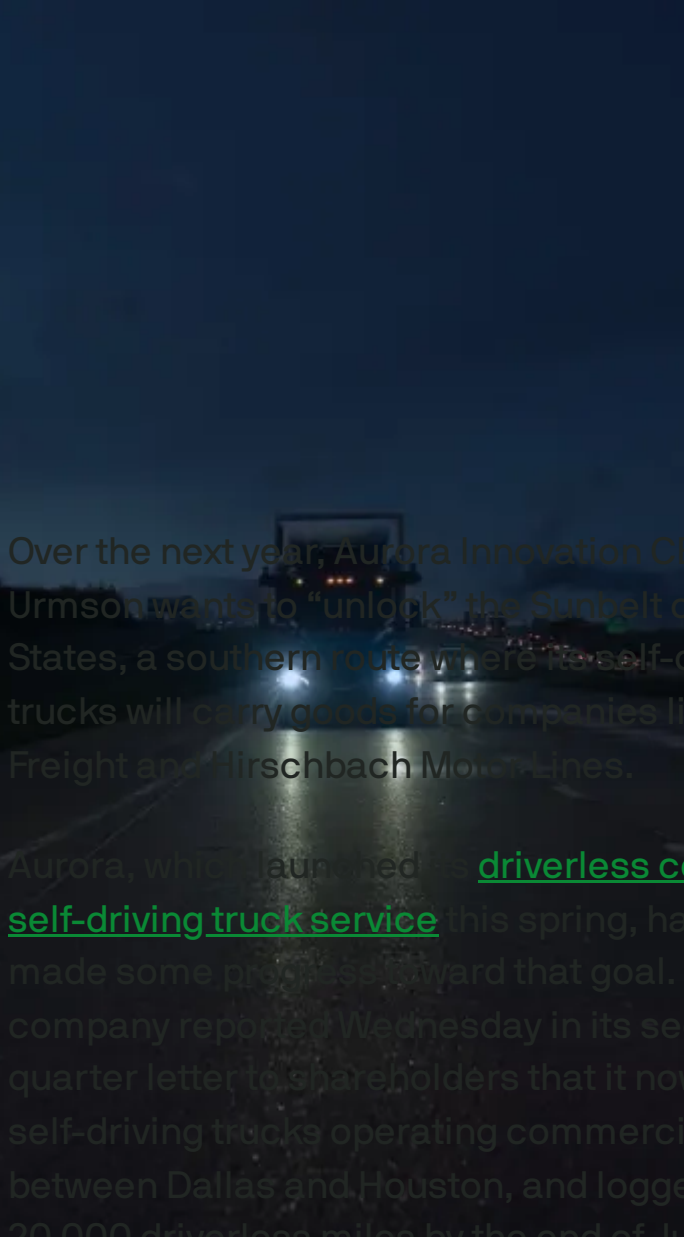


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TRANSPORTATION



Aurora's autonomous trucks are now driving at night. Its next big challenge is rain.



Over the next year, Aurora Innovation CEO Chris Urmson wants to “unlock” the Sunbelt of the United States, a southern route where its self-driving trucks will carry goods for companies like Uber Freight and Hirschbach Motor Lines.

Aurora, which launched its [driverless commercial self-driving truck service](#) this spring, has already made some progress toward that goal. The company reported Wednesday in its second-quarter letter to shareholders that it now has three self-driving trucks operating commercially between Dallas and Houston, and logged more than 20,000 driverless miles by the end of June. Its commercial self-driving trucks have a human “observer” in the cab, people who are not there to operate or intervene, according to the company.

Aurora has also opened a terminal in Phoenix, another physical sign of its Sunbelt trucking-route mission. Aurora is piloting autonomous trucking on a 15-hour route from its terminal in Fort Worth, Texas to Phoenix for customers, Hirschbach and Werner. The company’s terminals, which are located within one to five miles from the highway, require the driverless trucks to handle exits and surface streets.

But it’s the company’s ability to operate at night that helps it push into new territory. Aurora said Wednesday it has validated the ability for its driverless trucks to navigate highways and roads at

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night. This allows the trucks to travel longer distances — and importantly past the federally mandated service limitation for traditional human drivers. Truck drivers are allowed to drive up to 11 hours over a 14-hour period; and they can't do that day after day. Truck drivers are also required to take 10-hour breaks after completing a long-haul route.

“The value is really on longer lengths — so 600 miles is certainly a good range, where that is on the border of what's possible for people,” Urmson told TechCrunch in a recent interview, adding that ultimately he hopes Aurora trucks are carrying freight from Miami to California.

Urmson partially credits Aurora's proprietary, long-range lidar, which can detect objects in the dark more than 450 meters away, for its ability to operate at night. The lidar can identify pedestrians, vehicles, and debris up to 11-seconds sooner than a traditional driver, according to the company. Aurora has acquired two lidar companies since it was founded in 2017. The company bought [Blackmore](#), a Montana-based lidar startup, in May 2019 and OURS Technology in 2021.

Now, Urmson and the rest of Aurora's engineers are working to validate the driverless trucks' ability to operate in rain.

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“By the end of the year, we expect to be operating day, night, and in rain — if you can’t drive through the rain, ultimately, it’s hard to support these long operations because it’s raining somewhere,” he said.

Today, Aurora’s development fleet does operate in the rain and well enough that Urmson noted most would wonder why the company isn’t allowing its commercial trucks to do the same. Aurora has not completed the validation for that today, and “so we’re not willing to put that check mark next to it and let it go out there,” he noted.

Today, the company monitors weather on its one commercial route between Dallas and Houston. If adverse weather conditions like rain suddenly arise, those trucks are able to detect this and pull themselves off the road on their own where they will wait to be rescued, Urmson said.

“This year is really about building the capability toolbox so that the vehicles can drive where they need to,” he said in a nod to the company’s focus on validating driving at night and in the rain.

Next year, Aurora will focus on scaling its road network, in terms of distances and its fleet. Aurora plans to have “tens of driverless trucks” operating on public roads by the end of the year and “hundreds” by the end of 2026.

All of this, from the driverless trucks’ ability to function at night and in rain to opening more routes

and a with a larger fleet, will be critical if Aurora ever hopes to reach profitability.

The revenue-to-net income gap today is a large one. Aurora reported revenue of \$1 million in the second quarter and a net income loss of \$201 million, [according to its regulatory filing](#).

Topics: [Aurora Innovation](#) [self-driving trucks](#)

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Kirsten Korosec

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IMAGE CREDITS: ZOOX

TRANSPORTATION



Federal regulators give Zoox an exemption for its custom-built robotaxis

Kirsten Korosec — 12:02 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

The National Highway Traffic Safety Administration has given Zoox an exemption to demonstrate its custom-built robotaxis on public roads and closed a related investigation into whether the Amazon-owned company had sidestepped federal regulations.

The decision, which was announced Wednesday, clears up a long-standing debate over whether Zoox's custom-built autonomous vehicles complied with federal motor vehicle safety standards, which place requirements on vehicles such as having a steering wheel and pedals. Zoox

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had argued that it did and announced in July 2022 that it had self-certified; NHTSA balked. The agency opened an investigation in March 2023 to look into the matter, and specifically the process and data that Zoox had used to self-certify.

The investigation didn't slow Zoox's development and testing of its autonomous vehicle technology. In early 2023, Zoox began [testing its custom-built robotaxis](#), which don't have a steering wheel or other traditional controls, on public roads near its Foster City, California headquarters. The company has since expanded its testing footprint to [Las Vegas and San Francisco](#).

Zoox does not operate a commercial service yet. However, in San Francisco it has opened its robotaxis up to employees and hosted family and friends. Earlier this year, the company launched an Zoox Explorer program, aimed at early public riders, in Las Vegas.

For now, the exemption allows Zoox to demonstrate the robotaxis, not operate them commercially.

NHTSA's announcement is connected to its [new national framework](#), which the agency argues will make it easier for companies to deploy autonomous vehicles without traditional manual driving controls — like steering wheels, pedals, and sideview mirrors — at scale.

The framework allows NHTSA to green-light the sale and commercialization of autonomous vehicles that are not compliant with federal safety standards due to a lack of manual controls.

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The revised process involves an expedited application that allows companies like Zoox to receive exemptions for testing and demonstrations, and eventually, commercial operations. Zoox spokesperson Whitney Jencks said in an email that Zoox is working in close cooperation with NHTSA on this process, beginning with the demonstration exemption and followed by the commercial exemption.

As part of the agreement, NHTSA has closed its investigation into Zoox's self-certification of its AVs. Zoox has agreed to remove or cover all statements that its purpose-built vehicles comply with applicable Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standards.

Topics: [autonomous vehicles](#) [Transportation](#) [zoox](#)



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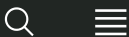
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Tesla is breaking up the team behind its [Dojo supercomputer](#), ending the automaker's play at developing in-house chips for driverless technology, according to [Bloomberg](#).

Dojo's lead, Peter Bannon, is leaving the company, and the remaining team members will be reassigned to other data center and compute projects within Tesla, per Bloomberg's reporting, which cited anonymous sources.

The disbanding of Tesla's Dojo efforts follows the departure of around 20 workers, who left the automaker to start their own [AI company called DensityAI](#). The new startup is reportedly coming out of stealth soon and is building chips, hardware, and software that will power data centers for AI that are used in robotics, by AI agents, and in automotive applications. DensityAI was founded by former Dojo head [Ganesh Venkataramanan](#) and ex-Tesla employees Bill Chang and Ben Floering.

It also comes at a crucial time for Tesla.

[CEO Elon Musk has pushed](#) to get shareholders to view Tesla as an AI and robotics company, despite a limited robotaxi launch in Austin this past June that featured Model Y vehicles with a human in the front passenger seat and resulted in a number of reported incidents of the vehicles exhibiting problematic driving behavior.

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Tesla’s decision to shut down Dojo, which Musk has been talking about since 2019, is a major shift in strategy. Musk has said that Dojo would be the cornerstone of Tesla’s AI ambitions and its goal to reach full self-driving due to its ability to “process truly vast amounts of video data.” He talked about Dojo, albeit briefly, as recently as the company’s second-quarter earnings call.

In 2023, Morgan Stanley predicted Dojo could add \$500 billion to the company’s market value by unlocking new revenue streams in the form of robotaxis and software services. Just last year, Musk noted that Tesla’s AI team would “[double down](#)” on Dojo in the lead-up to [Tesla’s robotaxi reveal](#), which happened in October.



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But talk about Dojo halted around August 2024, when Musk began touting Cortex instead, Tesla’s “giant new AI training supercluster being built at Tesla HQ in Austin to solve real-world AI.”

The Dojo project was one part supercomputer, one part in-house chip-making. Tesla unveiled its D1 chip when it formally announced Dojo at its first AI Day in 2021. [Venkataramanan](#) presented the chip, which Tesla said would be used alongside Nvidia's GPU to power the Dojo supercomputer. The automaker also said it was working on a next-gen D2 chip that would solve any information flow bottlenecks of its predecessor.

Sources told Bloomberg that now Tesla plans to increase its reliance on Nvidia, as well as other external tech partners like AMD for compute and Samsung for chip manufacturing. Tesla last month signed a [\\$16.5 billion deal with Samsung](#) to make its AI6 inference chips, a chip design that promises to scale from powering FSD and Tesla's Optimus humanoid robots all the way to high-performance AI training in data centers.

During Tesla's second-quarter earnings call, Musk hinted at potential redundancies.

"Thinking about Dojo 3 and the AI6 inference chip, it seems like intuitively, we want to try to find convergence there, where it's basically the same chip," Musk said.

The news comes as [Tesla's board offers Musk a \\$29 billion pay package](#) to keep him at Tesla and help push the company's AI efforts forward, rather than getting too sidetracked by his other companies, including the more pure-play AI startup xAI.

TechCrunch has reached out to Tesla for more information.

Have a sensitive tip or confidential documents? We're reporting on the inner workings of the AI industry — from the companies shaping its future to the people impacted by their decisions. Reach out to Rebecca Bellan at

rebecca.bellan@techcrunch.com and Maxwell Zeff
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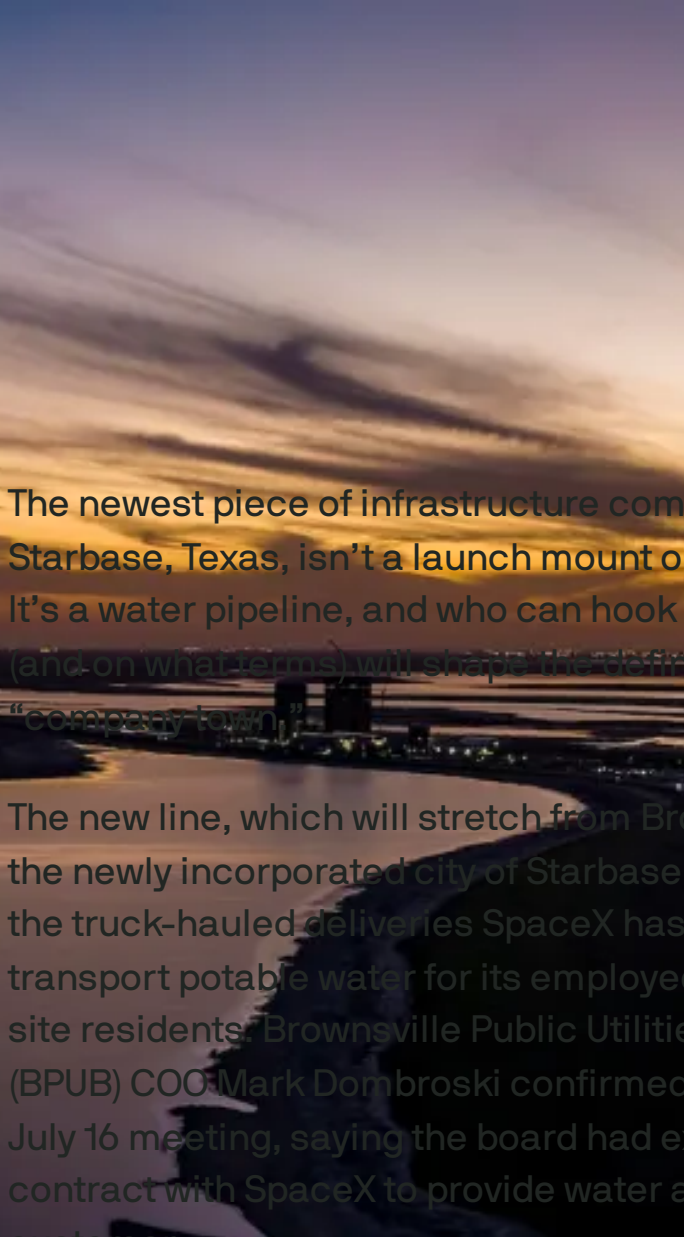
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SPACE

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SpaceX is building a
water pipeline to
Starbase — but access
comes with some
conditions



The newest piece of infrastructure coming to Starbase, Texas, isn't a launch mount or a booster. It's a water pipeline, and who can hook up a tap (and on what terms) will shape the definition of "company town."

The new line, which will stretch from Brownsville to the newly incorporated city of Starbase, will replace the truck-hauled deliveries SpaceX has used to transport potable water for its employees and on-site residents. Brownsville Public Utilities Board (BPUB) COO Mark Dombroski confirmed the line at a July 16 meeting, saying the board had executed a contract with SpaceX to provide water as an in-city customer.

IMAGE CREDITS: SPACEX

The BPUB approved the SpaceX contract on June 2, Dombroski told TechCrunch over email. He did not explain why SpaceX is being treated as an in-city nonresidential customer, which carries a cheaper rate class than outside-city customers, despite the fact that the company did, indeed, establish its own city.

"Under a non-standard development agreement, SpaceX will extend — at their cost — a line to a metering point within the city limits, then transport the water to Starbase," he continued. "They will also pay for and construct the improvements needed for BPUB to deliver water to the meter. This arrangement is intended to supersede the water hauling arrangement after SpaceX starts taking

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water through the meter. Timing is driven largely by SpaceX’s construction schedule.”

The potable water deliveries have been constrained by a 60,000 gallons per day cap under the current hauled-water purchase agreement between BPUB and SpaceX, according to a January 2024 letter from the Texas Commission on Environmental Quality (TCEQ). The pipeline would change that, making it easier for SpaceX to build out more amenities and housing for employees.

For a handful of non-SpaceX affiliated homes, getting access to that water may come with some terms and conditions.

In July, nearly 40 properties along the stretch between Brownsville and Boca Chica were abruptly cut off from the county water service, [according to the San Antonio Express-News](#). Cameron County previously delivered fresh water as a “courtesy” service to these properties, but the county now says it is Starbase’s responsibility to deliver water to these residents.

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Starbase disagrees: In July, Starbase city administrator Kent Myers reportedly sent a letter to a Cameron County commissioner saying the abrupt water cutoff “poses safety and public health risks.”

Starbase “has neither the legal authority nor operational capacity to deliver water to these residents,” Myers said.

Meanwhile, SpaceX has reportedly distributed an “unconditional and perpetual agreement” to non-SpaceX affiliated homes that would exchange access to Starbase’s water and sewer system for residents’ agreement to leave the area for “any and all launch, testing and other operational activities.”

The document also states that “SpaceX has no obligation to provide residents with access to SpaceX’s water and wastewater treatment,” nor does it guarantee the quality or volume of water and blocks residents from seeking “legal or monetary recourse” against the company.

A city — with no utilities

The newly incorporated city of Starbase, governed by SpaceX executives, is a separate municipal entity adjacent to and encompassing SpaceX’s sprawling South Texas launch site.

[The city was incorporated in May.](#) Only registered voters within the proposed boundary were allowed to vote on the incorporation. There were 247 lots inside that boundary, and only 10 were not owned by SpaceX, according to an affidavit submitted by SpaceX senior manager of spaceport operations Richard Cardile.

Even before the vote was cast, SpaceX had been working behind the scenes to formalize potable water provisions for employees and residents.

SpaceX established a state-regulated drinking-water system, replete with a half-a-million-gallon ground storage tank, plus service pumps, a chlorine analyzer, tank mixer, and other hardware, according to TCEQ records. The central water system, which is supplied by the two water haulers, is small compared to a city utility, but sizable for an on-site, industrial operation. It serves 239 residential service connections, or meters, which can include multiple units.

Starbase's role is limited by design: "The City of Starbase does not provide any utility services," Myers told TechCrunch. "These services are provided by SpaceX within the City Limits."

In practice, that means the forthcoming Brownsville-Starbase pipeline would feed a private, SpaceX-run water system. Neighbors don't automatically gain a right to a tap; any connection would be at SpaceX's discretion, and on SpaceX's terms.

The planned pipeline solves near-term scarcity for SpaceX employees and their families but doesn't create a public right to water.

According to public records, SpaceX has not obtained a Certificate of Convenience and Necessity (CCN), a Texas Public Utility Commission authorization that determines who may retail water, so has no obligation to serve third parties.

SpaceX did not respond to TechCrunch's questions on whether it will be adding public utilities to its long list of commercial services.

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